identity politics and good governance initiatives, creating a perception that Jharkhand is no longer the saffron citadel it used to be till a few years ago. The BJP, thus, has thought it fit to switch into battle mode, trying to gain the first-mover advantage.

If the swords are out between the BJP and Soren at the political level, the legal-constitutional realm is rife with tension too. Everyone awaits the next move in the long-drawn battle of attrition between the CM and Governor Ramesh Bais, a former BJP parliamentarian who was also a minister in the Atal Bihari Vajpayee-led NDA government. In January last week, Bais had returned the domicile bill—popularly known as the 1932 Khatiyan Bill—to the state government, asking it to review its legality in accordance with constitutional norms and court rulings.

Piloted by the Soren government and passed in a special assembly session convened on November 11, 2022, the proposed legislation redefines Jharkhand's 'local' populace as those whose ancestors' names find a mention in the 1932 land records (as against the present cut-off year of 1985), in order to extend to them benefits such as reservation in Grade 3 and 4 government jobs. With the CM yet to get off the hook in the office-of-profit issue that could cost him his assembly membership, the Khatiyan Bill was expected to consolidate his support base among the tribals and other *moolvasi* (original inhabitants) populations of Jharkhand, who form a bulk of the electorate and are the intended beneficiaries of this proposed legislation.

The share of just the Scheduled Tribes (STs) in Jharkhand's current population is believed to be much higher than the 26.3 per cent surveyed in the 2011 Census. Also, with about 35 per cent seats—both in the assembly (28 of 81) and Lok Sabha (5 of 14)—reserved for STs, the significance of the tribal vote is not lost on anyone. In fact, its impact goes much beyond these reserved seats. It's the tribal backlash against the Raghubar Das-led BJP government that was seen as the major contributor to Soren's electoral success in 2019. Then, the JMM-Congress combine swept 25 of the 28 seats reserved for STs whereas the BJP could bag just two seats.

The governor's decision to send the bill back for review has thrown a spanner in Soren's works. The CM, addressing party members at Dhanbad, seemed quite irked when, without taking names, he asked rhetorically why his pro-tribal policies, such as the domicile bill, were being termed "unconstitutional".

AS UNCERTAINTY LOOMS OVER JHARKHAND CM'S ASSEMBLY MEMBERSHIP, SHAH LAUNCHES ANOTHER BJP OFFENSIVE

Jharkhand has already seen a protracted spell of shadowboxing between the CM and the governor over the office-of-profit issue. In March 2022, Bais had forwarded a BJP petition seeking Soren's disqualification as an MLA for leasing a mine to himself in alleged violation of election laws. The EC reportedly sent its recommendation to Bais in August. It's been five months, but the governor has maintained a studied silence, keeping the CM on his toes and creating an air of political uncertainty. So, while on February 4, Amit Shah attacked Soren's regime for "letting down Jharkhand and its people", Soren accused the BJP-led Centre of "hatching a conspiracy" to unsettle his popular government. Expect this slugfest to get uglier by the day. ■



ANI

By Prashant Srivastava

Caste seems the ultimate determinant of politics in Uttar Pradesh. In the newest season of Mandal battle offensives, though, it is taking on Mandir in a bare-knuckled confrontation. Bihar education minister Chandrashekhar may have been the straw that stirred the *varna* drink first with cutting remarks on medieval Bhakti poet Tulsidas and his classic *Ramcharitmanas*, but senior Samajwadi Party leader Swami Prasad Maurya has opened up another flank in the debate—and roiled UP's political waters too in the process. While a section of his party now seems to want to make the most of it, pro-Hindutva voices are cavilling in anger. But even the BJP seems wary of letting Mandal leaders run away with the script, and has been forced into a pro-Mandal gesture on the caste census.

At recent media interactions, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav has played on the theme, calling himself a 'Shudra' and announcing his intention to ask Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath to define 'Shudra' and identify them when he meets him in the assembly. Trigger?